



DONATE

Goats and Soda

GOATS AND SODA

This nation has the fastest rising rate of cancer cases — and deaths — in the world

OCTOBER 22, 2025 · 8:49 PM ET



Ari Daniel



A cloud of smog hovers above Lebanon's capital Beirut on August 14, 2025. Air pollution from diesel generators and smokey tailpipes are among the reasons that cancer is surging in Lebanon.

Joseph Eid/AFP/via Getty Images

Ali Mokdad stands in the heart of Beirut. Cars and trucks and motorcycles rumble everywhere.

"If you look at a car passing by, you see smoke coming out of it — that's illegal in Lebanon. But nobody enforce[s] it," says Mokda, the chief strategy officer of population health at the University of Washington.

As a result, Beirut has terrible air quality and is often submerged under a blanket of exhaust. And it's not just in the big cities — vehicles belch pollution across the country.

It's one reason that cancer is surging in Lebanon. Mokdad co-authored a global survey that revealed that the tiny nation on the Mediterranean is experiencing the fastest increase in cancer incidence and mortality anywhere in the world. According to the study, published in *The Lancet*, the frequency of new cancer cases in Lebanon has increased by an astounding 162% from 1990 to 2023, with cancer-related deaths increasing by 80% over that same period. In 2023, for every 100,000 people in the country, there were 233.5 new cancer cases.

The news is sobering elsewhere too. The survey predicts that cancer cases and cancer deaths will continue to rise worldwide through at least 2050, especially in low- and middle-income countries.

Still, Lebanon has reason to be especially alarmed.

What's behind the dramatic rise in cancer in Lebanon

Mokdad grew up in Lebanon before moving abroad almost 40 years ago. For him, like many here, the disease is personal.

"I'm losing cousins," he says. "I'm scared. I'm losing them at a very young age. It's not only death. It's also diseases. They have so many health problems."



Ali Mokdad co-authored a global survey which revealed that, out of all the countries in the world, Lebanon is experiencing the fastest increase in cancer incidence and mortality.

Ari Daniel for NPR

There are various reasons why cancer is surging in Lebanon. A big one is air pollution from both vehicles and diesel-fueled generators that many homes and businesses use due to unreliable state electricity.

In addition, "we overuse chemicals for our agriculture," says Mokdad. Some of these compounds along with sewage ends up in certain rivers. "People don't drink it but they wash their tabbouleh and their fattoush with it. They're consuming this."

By far the biggest risk factor, however, is smoking.

"There is no more taboo about smoking," Mokdad says. "Everybody smokes. Kids smoke in front of their parents. Yesterday, I went with some of my friends for dinner. You come home, you stink of tobacco."

It's gotten to the point where Mokdad keeps a set of clothes in Lebanon that he only wears there.

There are no public health campaigns warning against the dangers of smoking or secondhand smoke. Instead, Mokdad says the government is actually in the business of buying and selling tobacco.

The inevitable result is that lung cancer rates have jumped nationwide. In addition, leukemia and pancreatic and liver cancers have risen. The increases in prostate, colon and breast cancers are all preventable through early screening and detection.

The issue, says Mokdad, is that although screening is available, most people don't know to seek it out. "Health education is a problem," he explains. "If you caught [cancer] earlier," people wouldn't have to die.

The global survey on cancer and Lebanon's troubling trends with the disease caught the attention of members of the Lebanese parliament. It's why they invited Mokdad to come talk to lawmakers and experts about his findings.

Change will be a journey, a slow one at that

Earlier this month, Mokdad traveled to Beirut for the meeting, which was held inside one of the Parliament buildings. After walking through the results of the study and describing the peril that cancer poses, Mokdad suggested to the officials that Lebanon could improve its health screening, ban smoking in public spaces and launch a set of aggressive anti-tobacco ads. By way of example, he pointed to a public health campaign launched by the Centers for Disease Control

and Prevention in the U.S. a decade ago, one that the CDC and other researchers say prevented 129,100 early deaths between 2012 and 2018.

Ali Mokdad briefs lawmakers about his report which shows how serious the frequency of cancer is in Lebanon. He tells lawmakers the country needs to improve its health screening, ban smoking in public spaces and launch an aggressive anti-tobacco campaign. "Many people in the parliament said, 'I'm not surprised with this finding.' And my question: What are you doing about it? "

Ari Daniel for NPR

Inaya Ezzeddine is a member of parliament and a physician who ran the proceedings. She explains that any kind of government response will take time. "It's a journey," she says. "It's not something that we can implement overnight because it has to do with a lot of sectors. We have to work hard toward this political will."

A committee will be formed to examine the data and determine which laws will need enacting or strengthening to address the problem.

One of the attendees, Iman Nuwayhid, a professor of public health at the American University of Beirut, believes that individuals should take responsibility too. "We're accountable to making our country cleaner, reduce pollution, improve the environment," he says. "Of course, the government plays a bigger role, but we have a big responsibility. Local communities again should push in that direction."

Mokdad argues that the time is now for the government to act and support people in making the right decisions about their health.

"I know Lebanese have to deal with a lot of things," he says. "But cancer is killing. Many people in the parliament said, 'I'm not surprised with this finding.' And my question: What are you doing about it? Why have you been waiting so long to take action?"

A couple blocks from the building where the meeting was held, a mother and son are seated outside, taking a break from work. The mom, 57-year-old, Najah Mourda, is smoking.

Najah Mourda, 57, on a lunch break with her son, Marwan Bizri. Mourda is a smoker and knows it's bad for her, but she hasn't been able to kick the habit.

Ari Daniel for NPR

She says she's recently lost several loved ones to cancer — her mother, her sister and a close friend. "It's very dangerous and I'm afraid of it," she says.

Mourda is hopeful that the government will do something, even while acknowledging that she shouldn't be smoking. She knows it's bad for her. She's tried to stop but hasn't been able to kick the habit.

Her son, Marwan Bizri, looks on. "Lebanese people are dying because of cancer," he says. "We're losing people we love."

cancer'



The news you need to start your day

Our journalists summarize the biggest stories in the Up First newsletter so you can stay informed, not overwhelmed.

SIGN UP

[See more subscription options](#)

By subscribing, you acknowledge and agree to NPR's [Terms of Use](#) and [Privacy Policy](#).
NPR may share your name and email address with your NPR station. [See Details](#).

More Stories From NPR

GOATS AND SODA

Just because she won a Nobel doesn't mean Malala didn't break some rules in college

GOATS AND SODA

Some ant architects design a colony to cut the risk of disease. Humans, take note!

GOATS AND SODA

For years, men controlled one village's coffee industry — but one woman changed that

GOATS AND SODA

Study: We're losing the war against drug-resistant infections faster than we thought

GOATS AND SODA

Afghan earthquake triggers contradictory Taliban tactics on rescuing women

GOATS AND SODA

This wedding photographer now removes landmines for a group that's won a top prize

Popular on NPR.org

2025 GOVERNMENT SHUTDOWN

The federal government is still shut down. Here's what that means across the country

LIVING BETTER

Mental exercise can reverse a brain change linked to aging, study finds

MUSIC

After months of the same songs on the Hot 100, 'Billboard' tweaks its rules



POLITICS

Karine Jean-Pierre on why she left the Democrats — and calls herself independent

ASIA

5 things to know about Sanae Takaichi, Japan's first female prime minister

SCIENCE

Iceland reports the presence of mosquitoes for the first time, as climate warms

NPR Editors' Picks

FAR-FLUNG POSTCARDS

Greetings from an Indian Railways coach, with spectacular views from Mumbai to Goa

POLITICS

Mamdani's rise in NYC reflects a generational fight within the Democratic Party

POLITICS

Trump uses 'common sense' to make a political point. It has populist appeal

WORD OF THE WEEK

The not-so-spooky origins of 'ghost' — and why the word still haunts our language

MIDDLE EAST CONFLICT

American 'Bibisitters' try to keep the Israel-Hamas truce on track

SPORTS

Spanish league cancels plans for Barcelona to play regular-season match in Miami

READ & LISTEN

Home

News

Culture

Music

Podcasts & Shows

CONNECT

Newsletters

Facebook

Instagram

Press

Public Editor

Corrections

Transcripts

Contact & Help

ABOUT NPR

Overview

Diversity

NPR Network

Accessibility

Ethics

Finances

GET INVOLVED

Support Public Radio

Sponsor NPR

NPR Careers

NPR Shop

NPR Events

NPR Extra

[terms of use](#)

[privacy](#)

[your privacy choices](#)

[text only](#)

